

Fasteners

Making a successful garment is not just about getting the material, style, and size right. The item of clothing also needs to stay in place so that it doesn't fall open—or down—for as long as it's worn. Since ancient times, inventive minds have come up with a range of ingenious fasteners for clothes, from buckles and buttons to intricate locking arrangements of teeth, eyes, and hooks.

Securing your sword

- **What?** Buckles
- **Who?** Possibly the Romans
- **Where and when?** Possibly Italy, c. 100 BCE

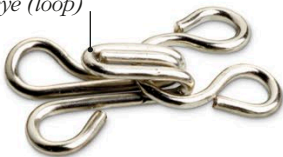
It's not known when buckles first appeared, but they were certainly widely used by the Romans. They were mainly employed by soldiers to secure their body armor and weapons. Until the 15th century, when manufacturing



Bronze buckle, 7th century

methods improved, buckles in Europe were expensive and mainly worn by wealthy people.

Hook fastened through eye (loop)



Hook and eye

- **What?** Hook and eye fasteners
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** England, 14th century

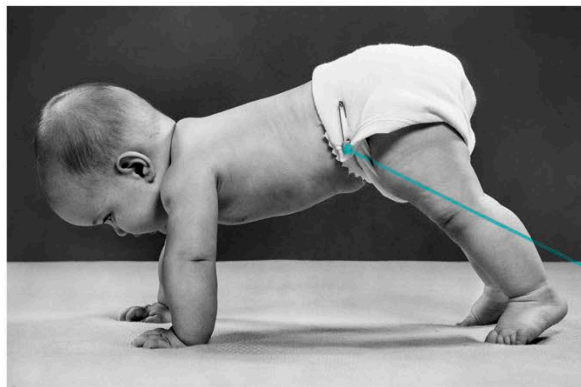
One of the simplest types of fastener for clothes consists of a small metal hook that fits snugly inside a loop or "eye." Widely used since medieval times, the hook and eye fastener is believed to have first appeared in England, where it was known as "crochet and loop" (crochet is a French term for "hook"). The fastener is still used today, particularly for bras.



Button up!

- **What?** Buttons
- **Who?** Possibly Indus Valley Civilization
- **Where and when?** Mohenjo Daro, Pakistan, c. 2500 BCE

The oldest-known button was produced by the Indus Valley Civilization of Pakistan and northern India about 5,000 years ago. Made of seashell, it would have fitted into a loop of cloth and was probably more ornamental than functional. Reinforced buttonholes, which allow rows of buttons to be made, were not invented until the 13th century.



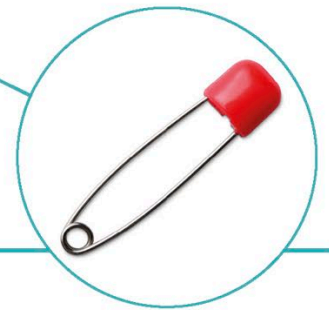
Diaper pins

- **What?** Safety pin
- **Who?** Walter Hunt
- **Where and when?** US, 1849

A safety pin uses a spring mechanism to keep the pin safely in place inside a clasp. As seen above, it is often used for holding together pieces of material, such

STEEL PINS

Although Hunt's safety pin was made out of brass, modern safety pins are usually made from stainless steel and come in a variety of sizes.



as cloth diapers. It was the brainchild of the American inventor Walter Hunt who sold his patent for just \$400 to a company that went on to make millions from the device.